

Afternoon Discoveries

September 22, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Science Fiction & Fantasy

Tuesday brings two kinds of impossible into the same room. Today's science fiction keeps asking what happens when technology, ecology, or the body changes faster than our habits can follow. The fantasy selections lean toward older stories being retold, dangerous books, magical professions, and worlds where survival depends on learning the rules quickly.

All links in today's edition were checked against the linked publisher, magazine, author, or literary organization page on September 22, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Fold Catastrophes - Peter Watts

Peter Watts's first short-fiction collection since 2013 arrives today from Tachyon Publications. The stories move through brain-computer interfaces, possible life inside stars, manipulated human behavior, ecological collapse, and the kind of hard science-fiction questions that become unsettling because the technology is never separate from the people using it. The collection also includes previously unpublished work. If you like speculative fiction that pushes an idea until it starts changing the moral problem underneath it, this is a strong place to begin.

[Visit the publisher page for Fold Catastrophes](#)

New Worlds, New Rules

Witch Daughter - Tanaz Bhathena

Bhathena's adult debut returns to the story of Tahmineh from the *Shahnameh* and asks what changes when a woman remembered as a temptress or witch is allowed to become the centre of her own story. Set in ancient Persia, the novel follows Tahmineh as rumours of witchcraft narrow her future and a prophecy points her toward the warrior Rostam and the tragedy to come. Grand Central Publishing releases the book today.

[Visit the publisher page for Witch Daughter](#)

The Thrice-Bound Fool - Christopher Buehlman

Reactor has opened an extended preview of Buehlman's next Blacktongue adventure with the first three chapters. Kinch Na Shannack is trying to decipher a stolen, sentient book that is dangerous even when it is closed, while Galva protects him because what the book contains may be the key to stopping the forces threatening her queen. The novel publishes October 13, but this preview gives readers a substantial early return to the series rather than a one-page teaser.

[Read the opening chapters at Reactor](#)

As You Wake, Break the Shell - Excerpt - Becky Chambers

Chambers's new science-fiction duology begins on the resource-poor planet Fortune, where survival is ordinary enough to become routine. The excerpt introduces Signy, a botanist who bio-prints medicine, and Cora, a pilot bonded to the living ships that connect scattered settlements. Reactor published this early look on September 17, ahead of the novel's October 13 release. The appeal is not just the biological technology or the living spacecraft, but the way both are tied to care, risk, and the compromises people make to keep a community functioning.

[Read the excerpt at Reactor](#)

Today's free edition moves from hard science fiction to mythic retelling, then into two substantial previews of October books. The complete edition continues below with new releases, recent short fiction, one upcoming climate novella, and three older stories worth returning to.
Thank you for reading!

✓ **Subscribed**

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

Science Fiction & Fantasy Discoveries

The Strangers **- Naomi Alderman**

Alderman's new novel, released today by Little, Brown, begins with grief and a wildlife camera. After the narrator's mother dies, the camera captures a strange new creature that soon seems to be appearing everywhere. The book deliberately blurs memoir and speculative fiction as the mysterious "mimmoths" spread across countries and become entangled with fear, fascination, public argument, and the narrator's private mourning. It looks especially interesting for readers who like speculative premises used to disturb the boundary between an invented world and the one outside the book.

[Visit the publisher page for The Strangers](#)

Empire **- Sabaa Tahir**

The *Heir* duology closes today with a fantasy built around a collapsing empire, an ancient evil, and two characters being pulled in different directions by duty and attachment. Crown prince Quil is trying to hold the Martial Empire together while Sirsha remains bound to Div, the force threatening to consume her. Because this is the conclusion to an existing arc, it is one for readers already invested in *Heir*, but the publisher's page makes the scale clear: war, inheritance, loyalty, and the cost of choosing who gets saved.

[Visit the publisher page for Empire](#)

The Henchperson's Guide to Unionizing **- Marshall J. Moore**

Released today by Bantam, Moore's fantasy turns the traditional monster story sideways and gives the workers around the monsters the centre of the page. A lab assistant, a deeply dissatisfied bride, and a feline familiar begin comparing what their powerful masters demand of them and what it might take to stop accepting those terms. The premise is playful, but the publisher's description keeps returning to friendship, self-worth, solidarity, and the strange relief of discovering that the problem may not be yours alone.

[Visit the publisher page for The Henchperson's Guide to Unionizing](#)

Death in Verse **- Julie Lew**

Bronte Cade arrives at a retreat for magical poets by pretending to be her missing mother. Instead of finding answers, she finds an abandoned island, six other poets, an unfinished line, and an enchanted gramophone telling them to complete a spell before the next ferry arrives. There is one additional problem: Bronte is not magical. Union Square & Co. releases the novel today, and the setup gives it a useful crossing point between fantasy, dark academia, locked-room mystery, and a story about language being dangerous in a literal way.

[Visit the publisher page for Death in Verse](#)

The Passing of the Dragon and Other Stories **- Ken Liu**

Liu's new collection gathers thirteen stories that move between science fiction and fantasy without treating the border as especially important. The publisher describes dragons over small towns, mech-animals dreaming of freedom, techno-witches resisting machine rule, a painter wrestling with transcendence, and a consciousness watching cosmic death and rebirth. It was published earlier this month, and it is a useful choice for readers who want one book that can move across both of Tuesday's genres without feeling like a sampler assembled from unrelated parts.

[Visit the publisher page for The Passing of the Dragon and Other Stories](#)

Scion **- James Islington**

Scion shifts Islington into cyberpunk. Its narrator, Azure, is an assassin in a world where wealth can buy extraordinary longevity and poverty keeps life brutally short. The job that disrupts his routine is the opposite of what he usually does: protect one of the rich instead of killing one. Orion published the book on September 1, and the premise is built around debt, genetic advantage, engineered inequality, and the possibility that a person can become very good at surviving inside a system without becoming comfortable with what the system is.

[Visit the publisher page for Scion](#)

Dreamweavers **- Alexander Weinstein**

In this September story from *Lightspeed*, people can buy elaborate dreamscapes while the physical world becomes harder to inhabit. The opening gives us a former dream fabricator moving among wealthy clients who can afford private digital escapes as environmental conditions deteriorate outside. Weinstein's premise is immediately legible, but the interesting pressure comes from what the technology allows people with enough money to stop noticing.

[Read Dreamweavers in Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Long Goodbyes **- Anya Ow**

Ow begins with an act of care: Sui helping an aging five-tailed Zheng relieve itself when its body can no longer do the work alone. From there, the story uses a fantasy creature to approach the long, repetitive labour of caring for a beloved animal through decline. *Lightspeed* also published an author spotlight in which Ow describes the story as growing from years of caring for an elderly cat. That grounding gives the fantastical animal an unusually familiar emotional weight.

[Read Long Goodbyes in Lightspeed Magazine](#)

We, The Drowning - Lindz McLeod

Android Press is preparing this climate-fiction novella for September 29. Cole has grown up among the Parched, a desert community built around preserving water and surviving ecological collapse. Then a girl from the Flooded arrives alive, bringing him into contact with a movement that believes humanity should surrender itself to the sea so the planet can recover. The premise creates a sharp conflict between two responses to climate disaster: survival at almost any cost, and the belief that survival itself may be the problem.

[Visit the publisher page for We, The Drowning](#)

Special Recommendations

The Water That Falls on You from Nowhere - John Chu

The speculative rule is almost absurdly simple: whenever someone lies, water falls from the sky. A small lie brings a mist. A larger one can bring much more. Chu uses that impossible condition to make ordinary evasions physically visible as Matt tries to navigate love, family, and coming out to his traditional Chinese parents. The story won the 2014 Hugo Award for Best Short Story, but the reason to return to it is not the award. It is the precision with which one magical rule keeps tightening every conversation.

[Read The Water That Falls on You from Nowhere at Reactor](#)

The Lady Astronaut of Mars - Mary Robinette Kowal

Long before the Lady Astronaut novels expanded the world around her, Elma York appeared here as an older astronaut facing one last possible mission. Mars is no longer the impossible destination it once was, but the decision in front of Elma is still enormous because leaving would mean choosing exploration while her husband is seriously ill. The story won the 2014 Hugo Award for Best Novelette and remains a compact example of science fiction making a technological future matter through an intimate choice.

[Read The Lady Astronaut of Mars at Reactor](#)

Folding Beijing - Hao Jingfang, translated by Ken Liu

Beijing physically folds to divide its population into different spaces and different allotments of time. Lao Dao, a waste worker, crosses those boundaries carrying a message because he needs money for a child's education. The scale of the city is enormous, but the story keeps its attention on work, food, clothes, money, and the small practical decisions that make inequality feel ordinary to the people living inside it. It won the 2016 Hugo Award for Best Novelette and still rewards a return because the speculative architecture never replaces the human details.

Read Folding Beijing in Uncanny Magazine

Today's selections keep returning to the same useful tension: speculative fiction can make a world strange very quickly, but the best of it still has to make the people inside that world recognizable. A sentient book, a living spacecraft, a new species, a divided climate, or rain that punishes lies only matters once somebody has to live with the rule.

Thank you for reading and supporting Among the Letters. I hope one of today's pieces gives you a new writer to follow, a book to put aside for later, or a story worth reading before the day is over.

Take care!